

MARISSA E. THOMPSON

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

Social Stratification • Sociology of Education • Race & Ethnicity • Public Policy

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Columbia University Assistant Professor, Department of Sociology Co-Director, Center for the Study of Wealth and Inequality Faculty Affiliate, Columbia Population Research Center Faculty Affiliate, Data Science Institute	2022-present
University of Michigan Postdoctoral Fellow, Education Policy Initiative, Ford School of Public Policy Research Affiliate, Stone Center for Inequality Dynamics	2021-2022

EDUCATION

Ph.D., Sociology of Education & Education Policy Stanford University	2021
M.A., Sociology Stanford University	2019
B.S.E., Chemical and Biomolecular Engineering <i>magna cum laude</i> University of Pennsylvania	2016

PUBLICATIONS

* denotes joint lead authorship, ^ denotes student co-author

Peer-Reviewed Publications:

- Forth.* **Marissa E. Thompson**, Sam Trejo, AJ Alvero, and Daphne O. Martschenko. “‘*Being Black is Not Just Some Costume*’: How Black Americans narrate moral judgments regarding racial boundary-crossing.” Forthcoming at *Social Problems*.
- Forth.* Elizabeth Burland, Jasmina Camo Biogralija, Xavier Fields[^], Kelcie Ferrara-Gerson[^], Katherine Micheltore, Megan Tompkins Stange, Kevin Stange, Nathan Sotherland[^], and **Marissa E. Thompson** (authorship alphabetical). “Bureaucrats and Burden: Understanding Variation in Take-up of a Need-Based Aid Program.” Forthcoming at the *American Educational Research Journal*. [Working Paper]
- 2026 **Marissa E. Thompson**, Sam Trejo, AJ Alvero, and Daphne O. Martschenko. “Policing the boundaries of Blackness: How Black and White Americans evaluate racial self-identifications.” *American Journal of Sociology*. [Paper] [Data/Code] [Pre-Registration]
- 2026 **Marissa E. Thompson**. “‘Paper, practice, ancestry, culture’: Racial frames and contested racial/ethnic census categories.” *Social Forces*. [Paper]

- 2026 **Marissa E. Thompson**, AJ Alvero, Sam Trejo and Daphne O. Martschenko. “*What does it mean to be Black?: Experimental evidence on the situational deployment of racial schemas.*” *Sociology of Race and Ethnicity*. [Paper] [Data/Code] [Pre-Registration]
- 2024 **Marissa E. Thompson**, Tobias Dalberg, and Elizabeth E. Bruch. “Gender Segregation and Decision-Making in Undergraduate Course-Taking.” *Sociological Science*. [Paper] [Data/Code]
- 2024 **Marissa E. Thompson**. “The Effect of Academic Outcomes, Equity, and Student Demographics on Parental Preferences for Schools: Evidence from a Survey Experiment.” *Social Forces*. [Paper] [Data/Code] [Pre-Registration]
- Best Post-PhD Paper Award (Co-Winner), Sociology of Education Association, 2025
- 2024 **Marissa E. Thompson*** and Sam Trejo*. “*My School District Isn’t Segregated: Experimental Evidence on the Effect of Information on Parental Preferences Regarding School Segregation.*” *Sociology of Education*. [Paper] [Data/Code] [Pre-Registration]
- 2024 **Marissa E. Thompson**. “Examining the Black Gender Gap in Educational Attainment: The Role of Exclusionary School Discipline & Criminal Justice Contact.” *Social Forces*. [Paper]
- 2023 **Marissa E. Thompson**, Christina Weiland, Meghan P. McCormick, Catherine Snow, and Jason Sachs. “The Role of Early Schooling in Shaping Inequality in Academic, Executive Functioning, and Social-Emotional Skills.” *Socius*. [Paper]
- 2023 René F. Kizilcec, Rachel B. Baker, Elizabeth Bruch, Kalena E. Cortes, Laura T. Hamilton, David Nathan Lang, Zachary A. Pardos, **Marissa E. Thompson**, and Mitchell L. Stevens. “From Pipelines to Pathways in the Study of Academic Progress.” *Science* (Policy Forum). [Paper]
- 2023 Kaylee T. Matheny*, **Marissa E. Thompson***, Carrie Townley-Flores*, and Sean F. Reardon. “Uneven Progress: Recent Trends in Academic Performance Among U.S. School Districts.” *American Educational Research Journal*. [Paper]
- 2021 **Marissa E. Thompson**. “Grade Expectations: The Role of First-Year Grades in Predicting the Pursuit of STEM Majors for First- and Continuing-Generation Students.” *The Journal of Higher Education*. [Paper]
- 2021 Sorathan Chaturapruek, Tobias Dalberg, **Marissa E. Thompson**, Sonia Giebel, Monique H. Harrison, Ramesh Johari, Mitchell L. Stevens, and René Kizilcec. “Studying Undergraduate Course Consideration at Scale.” *AERA Open*. [Paper] [Data/Code]
- 2020 Adina D. Sterling, **Marissa E. Thompson**, Shiya Wang, Abisola Kusimo, Shannon Gilmartin, and Sheri Sheppard. “The Confidence Gap Predicts the Gender Pay Gap Among STEM Graduates.” *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*. [Paper]
- 2019 Shannon Gilmartin, **Marissa E. Thompson**, Emily Morton, Helen Chen, Anne Colby, and Sheri Sheppard. “Entrepreneurial Intent of Engineering and Business Undergraduate Students.” *Journal of Engineering Education*. [Paper]
- 2016 Ki Jun Yu, Duygu Kuzum, Suk Won Hwang, Bong Hoon Kim, Halvor Juul, Nam Heon Kim, Sang Min Won, Ken Chiang, Michael Trumpis, Andrew G. Richardson, Huanyu Cheng, Hui Fang, **Marissa E. Thompson**, Hank Bink, Delia Talos, Kyung Jin Seo, Hee Nam Lee, Seung Kyun Kang, Jae Hwan Kim, Jung Yup Lee, Younggang Huang, Frances E. Jensen, Marc A. Dichter, Timothy H. Lucas, Jonathan Viventi, Brian Litt, and John A. Rogers. “Bioresorbable Silicon Electronics for Transient Spatiotemporal Mapping of Electrical Activity from the Cerebral Cortex.” *Nature Materials*. [Paper]

Working Papers & Manuscripts Under Review:

Adina D. Sterling, **Marissa E. Thompson**, and Devon Rojas[^]. “When Employer Commitment Does (Not) Produce Racialized Effects in Hiring.” Revise & resubmit, *Journal of Economics, Race, and Policy*.

Sam Trejo and **Marissa E. Thompson**. “DNA Reveals the Growing Ancestral Diversity of the United States.” Under Review. [Working Paper]

Marissa E. Thompson, Katherine Micheltmore, Kelcie Ferrara-Gerson[^], Nathan Sotherland[^], Kevin Stange. “One Fell Through the Safety Net: Embeddedness and the Take Up of Social Benefits.” Under Review.

Policy Briefs & Other Publications:

- 2026 Kevin Stange, Kelcie Ferrara-Gerson, Margaret Peterman, Nelson Oviedo, Nathan Sotherland, Nicole Wagner Lam, **Marissa E. Thompson**, and Katherine Micheltmore. “The Effectiveness of Need-Based Financial Aid: Evidence from Michigan’s Tuition Incentive Program.” EPI Policy Brief. [Link]
- 2024 Kelcie Gerson, Katherine Micheltmore, Nathan Sotherland, Kevin Stange, and **Marissa E. Thompson**. “Michigan’s Tuition Incentive Program: An Initial Look at Take-up.” EPI Policy Brief. [Link]
- 2021 **Marissa E. Thompson**. “Who’s getting pulled in weed-out courses for STEM majors?” Brown Center Chalkboard, Brookings Institution. [Link]

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

- Postdoctoral Fellowship, National Academy of Education & Spencer Foundation – \$70,000 2024-2025
- Russell Sage Foundation & Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation Pipeline Grant – \$35,000 2024
for “*What is fair? Disentangling public conceptions of merit and equity in the age of inequality*”
P.I. Marissa Thompson
- Hettelman Junior Faculty Summer Research Grant, Columbia University – \$6,000 2024
- Alliance Joint Projects Grant, Columbia University & Sciences Po (Paris) – \$15,000 2023
for “*A Columbia-Sciences Po Joint Course: Race, Discrimination, and Racial Inequalities on Both Sides of the Atlantic*”
P.I.s Thomas DiPrete, Mirna Safi & Marissa Thompson
- Columbia Population Research Center Seed Grant, Columbia University – \$20,000 2022
for “*Race, Genetic Ancestry, and Context: Exploring How Genetic Ancestry Tests Influence Conceptions of Race*”
P.I.s Marissa Thompson, Sam Trejo, Daphne Martschenko, & AJ Alvero
- Institute of Education Sciences (IES) Grant – \$2,702,034 2022-2026
for “*Early First-Dollar Categorical Need-Based Aid: A New Model for Making College Affordable?*”
P.I. Kevin Stange
- Postdoctoral Training Fellowship, Institute of Education Sciences (IES) – \$55,000 2021-2022
- Center for American Democracy Grant, Stanford University – \$2,000 2020-2021

for “*Understanding Parental Attitudes Towards School Segregation*”

P.I.s Marissa Thompson and Sam Trejo

Karr Family Fellowship, Stanford University – \$19,000	2018-2019
Predoctoral Training Fellowship, Institute of Education Sciences (IES) – \$60,000	2017-2019
Graduate Fellowship in Science and Engineering, Stanford University – \$125,100	2016-2021
Enhancing Diversity in Graduate Education Fellowship, Stanford University – \$12,800	2016-2021

HONORS & AWARDS

Best Post-PhD Paper (Co-Winner), Sociology of Education Association	2025
Outstanding Predoctoral Fellow Award, Institute of Education Sciences (IES)	2021
Zeisberg Best Research Award in Chemical Engineering, American Institute of Chemical Engineers	2017
Melvin C. Molstad Prize in Chemical Engineering, University of Pennsylvania	2016
Exceptional Service Award, University of Pennsylvania	2016

RESEARCH AFFILIATIONS

Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL)	
Invited Researcher	2025-2028
University of Chicago	
Affiliate, Stone Center for Research on Wealth Inequality and Mobility	2023-2027
Stanford University	
Affiliate, Pathways Network	2021-present

TEACHING

Columbia University	
The Social World – Introduction to Sociology (Undergraduate): Spring 2026	
Education and Inequality (Undergraduate): Spring 2024, Spring 2026	
Race, Discrimination, and Racial Inequalities on Both Sides of the Atlantic (Undergraduate): Fall 2023, Fall 2025	
Sociology of Education (Graduate): Fall 2022	
Workshop on Wealth and Inequality (Graduate): Fall 2022, Fall 2023, Spring 2024	

INVITED PRESENTATIONS

(includes scheduled presentations)

2027	University of Texas at Austin, Population Research Center New York University - Abu Dhabi, Social Research and Public Policy Speaker Series
2026	RC-28 Thematic Meeting on Educational Inequalities (Keynote) University of California Berkeley, Department of Sociology

University of Pennsylvania, Graduate School of Education
Purdue University, Department of Sociology
University of Notre Dame, Center for Research on Educational Opportunity

- 2025 University of California Los Angeles, California Center for Population Research
Brown University, Annenberg Institute
Princeton University, Office of Population Research
Princeton University, Education Research Section
Vanderbilt University, Peabody Education Policy Seminar Series
Sciences Po Paris, Centre for Research on Social Inequalities
New York University, Sociology of Culture Workshop
- 2024 University of Pennsylvania, Population Studies Center
ENSAE Paris, Center for Research in Economics and Statistics
Sciences Po Paris, Centre for Research on Social Inequalities
University of Chicago, Stone Center for Research on Wealth Inequality and Mobility
University of Oxford, Classical and Computational Social Science Working Group
Stanford University, Center for Education Policy Analysis
Stanford University, Educational Opportunity Project & Institute for Advancing Just Societies
- 2023 University of Michigan, Center for Academic Innovation
University of Houston, Identity & Academic Motivation Lab
Columbia University, Population Research Center
Pennsylvania State University, Population Research Institute
Yale University, Center for Empirical Research on Stratification and Inequality
University of Wisconsin - Madison, Wisconsin Center for Educational Research
University of Wisconsin - Madison, Experimental Methods in Sociology Workshop
- 2022 Columbia University, Center for the Study of Wealth and Inequality
Drexel University, Pennoni Honors College (Panel)
Pennsylvania State University, College of Education
Columbia University, Quantitative Methods in the Social Sciences Research Seminar
- 2021 University of Michigan, Ford School of Public Policy
Howard University, School of Education
University of Florida, College of Education
Columbia University, Department of Sociology
- 2020 École Normale Supérieure, Département d'Études Cognitives

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

(includes scheduled presentations)

- 2026 RC-28: Research Committee on Social Stratification and Mobility (Seville, Spain)
Sociological Science Conference (Stanford, CA)
American Sociological Association (New York, NY)
- 2025 Sociology of Education Association (Pacific Grove, CA)
Population Association of America (Washington, D.C.)
Sociological Science Conference (Ithaca, NY)
- 2024 Sociology of Education Association (Pacific Grove, CA)
American Sociological Association (Montreal, Canada)

Race & Ancestry Symposium (University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA)

- 2023 Sociology of Education Association (Pacific Grove, CA)
Population Association of America (New Orleans, LA)
RC-28: Research Committee on Social Stratification and Mobility (Paris, France)
American Sociological Association (Philadelphia, PA)
- 2022 American Sociological Association (Los Angeles, CA)
Association of Black Sociologists (Chicago, IL)
- 2021 American Sociological Association (Virtual)
Association for Education Finance and Policy (Virtual)
Empowering Learners in AI (Virtual)
- 2020 Association for the Study of Higher Education (Virtual)
- 2019 Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (Denver, CO)
Sociology of Education Association (Pacific Grove, CA)
Association for Education Finance and Policy (Kansas City, MO)
American Sociological Association (New York, NY)
- 2018 American Society of Engineering Education (Salt Lake City, UT)
American Sociological Association (Philadelphia, PA)

DEPARTMENTAL & UNIVERSITY SERVICE

Graduate Admissions Committee, Columbia University	2023, 2026
Graduate & Undergraduate Thesis Prize Committee, Columbia University	2024

Student Advising:

PhD Dissertation Committee

Katerine Perez (Sociology, Columbia University, in progress)
Eva Chen (Sociology, Columbia University, in progress)
Elizabeth Adetiba (Sociology, Columbia University, 2025)
Bonnie Siegler (Sociology, Columbia University, 2025)
Dominic Walker (Sociology, Columbia University, 2024)
Asya Tsaturyan (Sociology, Columbia University, 2024)
Abbey Keener (Education, Columbia University, 2024)
Taylor Alexander (Education, University of Houston, 2023)

MA Thesis Advising

Kayla Smernoff (Sociology, Columbia University, 2026)
Amita Khurana (Sociology, Columbia University, 2024)

Undergraduate Advising

Gulnazik Bakhramova (Harriman Institute Summer Research Fellowship, Columbia University, 2026)
Kelly Yoshimura (Laidlaw Summer Program, Columbia University, 2023 & 2024)

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE & MEMBERSHIPS

Program Committee, Eastern Sociological Society Annual Meeting	2027
Council Member, ASA Section on Inequality, Poverty, & Mobility	2026-2029
Editorial Board, <i>Sociology of Education</i>	2026-2029
Outstanding Student Publication Award Committee, ASA Section on Biology & Society	2026
Council Member, ASA Section on Biology & Society	2025-2026
Participatory Budgeting Committee, ASA Section on Inequality, Poverty, & Mobility	2025-2026

Nominations Committee, ASA Section on Sociology of Education	2025-2026
Fall Conference Program Chair, Sociology of Education Association	2024
Session Organizer, PAA Annual Meeting	2024
Board of Directors, Sociology of Education Association	2023-2025
Outstanding Publication Award Committee, ASA Section on Methodology	2023
Clifford Clogg Award Committee, ASA Section on Methodology	2022
Council Member (Student), ASA Section on Methodology	2021-2023

Professional Association Memberships:

American Sociological Association (ASA)
 Association of Black Sociologists (ABS)
 Population Association of America (PAA)
 RC-28: Research Committee on Social Stratification and Mobility
 Sociology of Education Association (SEA)

Occasional Reviewer:

AERA Open, American Educational Research Journal, American Journal of Sociology, American Sociological Review, European Sociological Review, International Journal of Comparative Sociology, J-PAL North America Grants, Peabody Journal of Education, Social Currents, Social Forces, Social Problems, Social Science Research, Sociological Focus, Sociological Science, Sociology of Education, Socius, The Journal of Higher Education, The Sociological Quarterly, Time-Sharing Experiments in the Social Sciences (TESS) Grants